



by the *lwa*. Voudon rituals involve the active participation of everyone present. The goal of a Voudon ceremony, presided over by an *Ougan* (priest) or a *Mambo* (priestess), is to summon these spirits, by means of animal sacrifices and *veve* symbols drawn in corn starch, until one or more of the worshippers is possessed by a *lwa*. This is not possession in a diabolic sense: it is a positive affirmation of the vital links between the

living and the dead, between the material and the spiritual worlds. For all that, in the infinitely various world of Voudon, there can be a darker aspect. As well as priest figures, there are sorcerers, known as *Bokor* if male, *Caplata* if female, who call forth more malevolent spirits and summon the living dead—zombies. Such mythical figures can be thought of as a metaphor for the reduced, hardly human status of Haiti's enslaved population.

▲ **Voudon in practice**
Noise, music, and dance predominate in Voudon rituals, and everyone takes part. Such uninhibited celebrations alarmed early European observers.